

Exploring the Divergent Political Trajectories of Nicaragua and Costa Rica: A Historical and Contemporary Analysis.

POLI 227: Developing Areas: Introduction

Nicaragua and Costa Rica share a history of colonization, independence, and a tumultuous past that led to divergent political trajectories. While Costa Rica is celebrated as a stable democracy in Central America, Nicaragua continues to face challenges in consolidating its democracy due to the authoritarian tendencies of its leaders. In this essay, we will examine the factors that have contributed to this divergence in outcomes. To achieve this objective, this essay will draw on the required readings, including the articles by Martínez Franzoni and Sánchez-Ancochea (2014), Pettiford (1999), McConnell (2007), and Cupples and Glynn (2018). The essay will begin by providing a historical background of the two countries and their political trajectories before examining the factors that have contributed to the divergence in outcomes.

First, we will go over the historical background of both countries.

Even before electoral mechanisms emerged, Nicaragua developed and strengthened a tradition of social mobilization. As democracy became institutionalized, mobilization was accompanied by a strengthening national legislature and growing judicial power. Multiple

scholars discuss this topic, notably 2016's "The Authoritarian Executive? Horizontal and Vertical Accountability in Nicaragua." that notes that popular mobilization even existed before the Somoza regime. According to this source, the presidencies of Daniel Ortega, Violeta Chamorro, and Arnoldo Alemán represented the Sandinista, Conservative, and Liberal parties, respectively. Each period evidenced efforts at an authoritarian presidency that encountered resistance from both society and the legislature. This social history provides insights into the accountability of strong presidents in a mobilized society with an active legislature. The constitutional rules for Nicaragua's presidency lend themselves to power concentration in a manner beyond that of many other developing democracies (McConnell, 2007). President Aleman's tenure was considered the most corrupt period, and it took four presidential elections, as well as legislative and municipal elections, to establish the electoral aspect of vertical accountability. However, even before electoral mechanisms emerged, Nicaragua developed and strengthened a tradition of social mobilization.

The accountability of leaders is essential in democratic regimes. The strength of institutions and, therefore, horizontal accountability has evolved over time in Nicaragua. Citizen mobilization has helped overcome the lack of horizontal accountability and played a crucial role in guaranteeing fair elections. The transition phase of democratization was concerned about the too powerful executive when there is a lack of accountability over other state institutions. The relationship between executive power and popular mobilization has two consequences, either popular mobilization is an asset to the rule of law or has undemocratic consequences.

According to Anderson's "Filling in the Missing Link between Universalism and Democracy: The Case of Costa Rica.", the constitutional rules for Nicaragua's presidency lend

themselves to power concentration in a manner beyond that of many other developing democracies. This concentration of power was particularly evident during President Aleman's period, which was considered the most corrupt.

Similarly to Nicaragua, it is during its founding period that Costa Rica determined its path. Costa Rica's democracy has been exceptional because it succeeded in creating a just society despite being surrounded by authoritarian and unstable regimes. However, this should not be exaggerated, especially regarding social justice. Indeed, electoral rights were initially restricted to a minority due to literacy requirements. In 1944, the president was directly elected, and in 1948 there was an armed uprising in response to perceived electoral fraud (Pettiford, 1999). Before handing back power, the major leader of the revolution, Figueres, banned the communist party, with limited US intervention in the country. Costa Rica is also the most successful case of universalism in South America, having accomplished the universalization of social security coverage, integrating social assistance with social security (Martínez Franzoni and Sánchez-Ancochea 2014). This coverage has been unified and offered to all workers and their families. Four successful cases of social coverage include Argentina, Uruguay, Costa Rica, and Chile, all of which are democracies; "By the early 1980s in those four countries, social spending as a percentage of GDP was between 12.2 percent and 15.5 percent" (Martínez Franzoni and Sánchez-Ancochea 2014). Democracy is a factor of social coverage, as the elected officials aim to reach the median voter. "By the late 1970s, most people had access to the same healthcare services provided by the Costa Rican Social Insurance Agency" (Caja Costarricense del Seguro Social, CCSS), and pension (Martínez Franzoni and Sánchez-Ancochea 2014).

Costa Rica is considered a liberal democracy, which means that personal freedom is not substantially limited (Pettiford, 1999). However, providing only liberal freedom is not enough to maintain a democracy; there must also be good democratic practices. Costa Rica has been a democracy for over 50 years, so the question is not whether it is a democracy but rather whether it will remain one. A liberal society can pose potential threats to democracy, so it is essential to maintain democracy's relevance so that protests are directed toward democratic channels.

Secondly, we will discuss the present situations of both countries.

Former President Ortega was re-elected on November 5, 2006. He was softer and more pragmatic than before, and he won by not needing a majority but only 35% as he successfully used the division in the opposition vote and proved himself as an adept opposition leader (McConnell, 2007). The real surprise of the election was the acceptance of the result by Nicaraguans and the United States. Nicaragua is one of the poorest countries with unequal income distribution: most FSLN (Sandinista National Liberation Front) voters come from low social classes and seek relief from poverty. Unemployment is high, and there is a strict budget from the government because of debt, so there are little resources for social spending, the lowest in South America.

In Nicaragua, the relationship between the executive power and popular mobilization has been a topic of concern during the transition phase of democratization. The lack of horizontal accountability over other state institutions has led to fears of an all-powerful executive, which

may lead to undemocratic consequences. However, popular mobilization has been an asset to the rule of law in Nicaragua. In fact, the history of Nicaragua's presidencies, including that of Ortega, shows that each period has seen efforts at an authoritarian presidency that encountered resistance from society or the legislature. This history provides insights into the accountability of strong presidents in a mobilized society with an active legislature.

However, it's important to note that Costa Rican democracy does not show serious signs of erosion, nor can it be regarded as a perfect expression of the people's voice. Few Costae Ricans participate in unions, associations, and civil society, which are crucial in the context of democratic participation (Pettiford, 1999). This lack of participation can limit the accountability of political elites and their responsiveness to citizens' needs.

Lastly, let's explore explanations for the divergence in outcomes.

The first difference noticeable is that of the degree to which anti-democratic incidents have a negative impact on the population. In Nicaragua, Ortega's party has great control over the state apparatus, and the institutions are deprived of their content. The National Assembly is mainly a machine for codifying decisions made via backroom pacts between party leaders, and the electoral system is less a guarantor of citizen rights than an administrative apparatus for defending partisan interests (Cupples and Glynn, 2018). The judiciary is too weak to dispense speedy justice and, like the comptroller's office, is sometimes feared as a tool of the parties that appoint its leadership, in exception of the army. On the other hand, multiple factors contribute

to democracy in Costa Rica, including an agrarian society, the lack of army since 1948, literacy, cultural homogeneity, and respect for the laws from elite politicians (Pettiford, 1999). However, Costa Rica's democracy does not show serious signs of erosion, nor can it be regarded as a perfect expression of the people's voice. Few Costa Ricans participate in unions, associations, and so on, which are crucial in the context of democratic participation.

Nicaragua is a country with a fragile democracy, where the president Daniel Ortega dismisses the rights of the citizens through an increasingly authoritarian power-bloc. This power-bloc is led by Ortega and Rosario Murillo, who work with other institutions like the Supreme Electoral Council, the Judiciary, the security forces, and most of the National Assembly. These institutions work together to suppress any event or claim that defies Ortega, who came to power after overthrowing dictator Somoza in 1970. Despite the multiple forms of insecurity, persistent poverty, and political tension in contemporary Nicaragua, the government does not do anything about it and evades engagement on such issues (Cupples and Glynn, 2018). This is also a display of how Costa Rica's strong commitment to democratic values and human rights has made such a difference. Indeed, by displaying its support for the Inter-American Human Rights System and its opposition to authoritarian regimes in the region, the country has clearly affirmed its foreign policy in the region. Additionally, recent political reforms, such as the electoral reform package of 2009, which aimed to increase transparency and accountability in the electoral process, and the constitutional reform process of 2020, which sought to strengthen the separation of powers and combat corruption, are promising steps towards strengthening Costa Rica's democratic institutions. To say the least, despite the challenges faced by Costa Rican democracy, there are still reasons to be optimistic about its future.

Overall, the reading suggests that Nicaragua's contemporary political situation is characterized by multiple forms of insecurity, persistent poverty, and political tension. The president's corruption is seen as a threat to the fragile democracy in the country, with an increasingly authoritarian power bloc emerging. While Ortega has managed to maintain his position, popular consent to his leadership is becoming increasingly difficult to secure. The lack of horizontal accountability and concentration of power in the presidency are concerns, but the country's tradition of social mobilization and a growing judicial power are positive developments (Anderson, 2006). For Costa Rica, the country's success in maintaining a liberal democracy with universal social coverage can be attributed to a combination of factors, including its socio-economic, historico-cultural, and politico-institutional context. Its history of successful democratization, lack of a standing army, cultural homogeneity, and respect for the rule of law have all contributed to its democratic stability. Additionally, the absence of interest groups with particularistic agendas, the strong presence of technopols (Martínez Franzoni and Sánchez-Ancochea 2014), and the lack of significant external pressures have enabled the successful implementation of universal social policies. However, it's important to note that Costa Rican democracy is not immune to challenges, such as low participation in civil society, economic crises, and rising crime rates.

Besides, the absence of interest groups with particularistic agendas is a dominant explanation of Costa Rica's uniqueness. The initial policy architecture and the legacies this architecture created are crucial mediating factors between democratic institutions and universal outcomes. Looking ahead, there are several key issues that will shape the future of Costa Rican democracy. One of the most pressing is the need to address growing socioeconomic inequality

in the country, which threatens to erode support for the democratic system. Another important challenge is to increase participation in civil society and promote greater citizen engagement in the democratic process. This could involve measures such as expanding access to education, increasing transparency in government decision-making, and empowering marginalized communities to participate in the political process.

To summarize this last part, Nicaragua's transition to democracy has been characterized by multiple forms of insecurity, persistent poverty, and political tension. The government's extreme levels of secrecy and lack of accountability, along with strong executive power, are concerns during the democratization transition phase. Nevertheless, citizen mobilization has helped overcome the lack of horizontal accountability and played a crucial role in guaranteeing fair elections. As democracy became institutionalized, mobilization was accompanied by a strengthening national legislature and growing judicial power. These factors show the difference with Costa Rica. Furthermore, the country has been a model of democratic stability and social inclusion in Latin America for over half a century. Its success can be attributed to a combination of factors, including its unique sociopolitical context, its commitment to democratic values and human rights, and its strong technocratic leadership (Martínez Franzoni and Sánchez-Ancochea, 2014). While challenges remain, such as socioeconomic inequality and low levels of civic engagement, there are reasons to be optimistic about the future of Costa Rican democracy. By continuing to prioritize transparency, accountability, and citizen engagement, Costa Rica can continue to be a beacon of democracy in the region.

To conclude this research essay, the divergent political trajectories of Nicaragua and Costa Rica can be attributed to a combination of historical, institutional, and socio-economic factors. While Costa Rica has enjoyed a stable democracy due to its strong institutions, citizen mobilization, and a culture of political compromise, Nicaragua has struggled with the concentration of power, weak institutions, and a lack of horizontal accountability. The presidencies of Ortega, Chamorro, and Aleman have all attempted to assert authoritarian tendencies that have encountered resistance from society or the legislature. However, the Nicaraguan people have a long history of social mobilization, and there are signs that the electoral aspect of vertical accountability is beginning to establish itself. The road to consolidating democracy in Nicaragua may be long and arduous, but it is essential to keep working towards a more accountable and democratic society. Costa Rica being much more transparent in its approach of democracy, its history has been a remarkable success story in a region plagued by authoritarianism and instability. The country's socio-economic, historico-cultural, and politico-institutional context has contributed to its democratic stability, with factors such as a lack of a standing army, cultural homogeneity, respect for the rule of law, and the absence of interest groups with particularistic agendas playing a significant role. Additionally, the country's universal social coverage has been a major achievement, made possible by the strong presence of technopols and the lack of significant external pressures. However, challenges such as low participation in civil society, economic crises, and rising crime rates highlight the need for continued vigilance in maintaining the country's democratic values. Ultimately, the success of

Costa Rican democracy will depend on its ability to address these challenges and remain responsive to the needs of its citizens.

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